

ANDROID 4.4 KITKAT

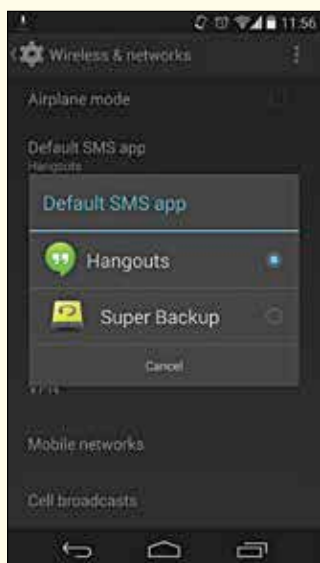
Google silently announced Android 4.4 – the latest iteration of the Android operating system with new features and performance enhancements. Baked with an elegant looking UI and a classy interface, it takes the look and feel of Android to a whole new level.

With so many new features, performance tweaks and cosmetic changes, Android 4.4 is a significant update with plenty of changes. Some changes worth noticing are Google Now integration, QuickOffice integration, bigger icons, new launcher and compatibility with old devices. Unlike previous iterations, KitKat takes up less memory, making it compatible with old and entry-level phones with 512MB RAM.

Here are some tips to help you maximise your Android 4.4 experience.

Remove SMS integration with Hangouts

In Android 4.4, Google has integrated the SMS app with the Google Hangouts app. This is one of KitKat's neater features as it enhances the traditional SMS



By default, your SMS app is integrated with Google Hangouts



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app. Though we like it, some of you may not and would prefer a separate SMS application. While the following step will remove the SMS integration with Google Hangouts, there's no separate SMS app provided, so you'll need to download a third-party app from Google Play.

Then navigate to Settings > Wireless and Networks > More > Default SMS app and choose the downloaded app that you wish to use.

Use 'OK Google' voice command

If you're not familiar with this feature, it lets you access the built-in voice assistant functionality, Google Now from your Android's home screen, without even touching the phone. All you have to do is say "OK Google" to get started.

At the time of writing, Google only offers the 'Google Now' functionality to U.S. residents. While it doesn't have international support for now, you can get this text-to-speech feature with a simple trick.

Go to Settings > Languages and input > Voice search > Change language to English (U.S.)

Add 'OK Google' search on Nexus 4

If you're a Nexus 4 user you can get Nexus 5's exclusive Google Now wakeup method on your phone. To get this feature, all you need is Google Launcher from Nexus 5 on your Nexus 4. Download the launcher APK file from <http://dgit.in/1gA47Np>, install it, then activate it from Settings > Home > Launcher > Select Google Experience Launcher. The launcher comes bundled with the 'OK Google' functionality. To activate it change Google Search's language to English (US). To do it, long press the home screen, then go to Settings > Voice > Set language to 'English (U.S.)'. You'll also need to set English (U.S.) language for offline speech recognition. Do this by long pressing the home screen, go to Settings

> Voice > Offline speech recognition > Set English (U.S.) as default. From the home screen say 'OK Google' and Google Now will appear on your Nexus 4 device.

Turn on hidden developer options

Google has removed the Developer options menu from settings since the Android 4.2 Jelly Bean update. This was a welcome step, since it wasn't considered very useful for non-developers earlier. If, however, you plan to install third-party custom ROMs or kernels, or do anything that will require developer access and USB debugging, you may want to retrieve the setting.

The option hasn't been removed completely, and is present as a hidden element. In order to make it visible, go to Settings > System > About phone > Tap 'Build number' seven (7x) times

A pop-up will appear saying 'You are now a developer!' Then, go back to Settings and you'll see a Developer options menu category under the System section.

Try the ART environment

Android 4.4 comes with an optional ART environment that replaces the default Dalvik environment. From the first iteration of Android, Dalvik is the default runtime environment.

ART stands for 'Android Run Time', which was introduced as an experiment by Google in Android 4.4. This runtime environment will make your phone faster and increase its battery life.

How, you ask? Well, Dalvik uses the 'Just-in-time' (JIT) process, which transforms source code into an executable program for all Android apps every single time they're started, hence consuming pro-